INTRODUCTION · REINVENTING MANAGEMENT

Two fundamentally different philosophies of management.

Same people. Same resources. Completely different organisations.

DIMENSION	EXTRACTIVE MANAGEMENT	REGENERATIVE MANAGEMENT
VIEW OF PEOPLE	Human Resources — to be allocated and utilised	Human Sources — to be partnered with and developed
CORE QUESTION	How do we get more from what we have?	What can we co-create with people as partners?
CONTROL MODE	Compliance through surveillance and pressure	Trust through developed capability and purpose
TIME HORIZON	This quarter. This year. This metric.	This decade. This legacy. This generation.
CULTURE	People perform when watched	People perform because they believe
PRODUCES	BUSYness — motion without meaning	High Performance — meaning that compounds

> "The shift from extractive to regenerative is not a values exercise. It is the most consequential structural decision a leader makes."

Kill BUSYness, Get High Performance · Manoj Onkar

CHAPTER 7

Leadership Creates

> *"Management maintains what exists. Leadership creates what has not yet been built."*

The choice between managing and creating is made every day.

There is a distinction that separates good organisations from great ones — and great leaders from merely competent ones. It is not intelligence. It is not experience. It is not even strategy.

It is the choice between managing and creating.

Management operates within an existing reality. It takes what is and makes it run better, smoother, more efficiently. Management is

necessary. Management is valuable. But management, on its own, will never produce High-Performance — because High-Performance is not the optimisation of what already exists. It is the creation of something not yet built.

Leadership creates. That is not a metaphor. It is a description of what leadership actually does: it brings new realities into being. A new culture. A new standard. A new relationship between the organisation and what it believes is possible. A new future that, before the leader chose to build it, existed only as potential.

The organisations that truly transform — that move from BUSY to High Performance, from ordinary to extraordinary — are always led by someone who made this choice. The choice to stop managing the existing reality and start creating a new one.

The Core Distinction

Look at how management and leadership actually differ in practice:

Management protects past success. Leadership builds new realities.

Management defends organisational silos. Leadership breaks organisational silos and builds ecosystem thinking.

Management optimises the current model. Leadership transforms the model entirely.

Management waits for the team to lead. Leadership creates space for everyone to lead while driving momentum forward.

Management produces BUSYness. Leadership produces High Performance.

John Kotter's research at Harvard — the most widely replicated body of work on the distinction between management and leadership — reaches exactly this conclusion: most organisations are overmanaged and underled. The problem is not talent. It is not a management competence problem. Because the orientation required for leadership — the deliberate choice to create new realities rather than optimise existing ones — is different from the orientation of management. And organisations rarely name that difference explicitly enough to develop it.

Three Comfort Zones Leaders Must Break

Comfort Zone One: Past Ways of Working.

The method that built you is now limiting you. The processes, habits, and structures that produced the organisation's early success have calcified into walls. The organisation defends the method instead of serving the mission. What methodology, process, or way of working in your organisation is defended with the phrase "this is what works" — even when the evidence that it still works is getting thinner?

Comfort Zone Two: Silos and Hierarchy.

The hierarchy that provided clarity at an earlier stage now slows decision-making and distances leadership from reality. The silos that made coordination efficient prevent the cross-functional collaboration that the next stage demands. Sales and Delivery

communicate through tickets instead of conversations. Finance and Operations occupy the same building and live in different worlds. The organisation is structured for the company it was — not the company it needs to become.

Comfort Zone Three: Past Success Itself.

Is your organisation using past success as a *seed* to grow from — a foundation to build on? Or as a reference standard and benchmark that has become a ceiling?

When Tufan Erginbilgiç became CEO of Rolls-Royce in 2023, he launched a strategic review he described as "necessarily chaotic." Not managed from the top. Not delegated to a strategy team. He involved 500 leaders across the organisation in making real choices about where Rolls-Royce would play and how it would win. The process was uncomfortable by design. The outcome was not just a strategy document. It was 500 leaders who had been inside the creation of a new reality — who understood the choices that had been made and why — and who could carry that understanding into every room the CEO cannot reach.

Breaking the comfort zone of past success is not ingratitude. It is the commitment to ensure that yesterday's achievement does not become tomorrow's limitation.

McKinsey's research on this pattern confirms it is not an outlier: companies that proactively disrupt their own business models before being disrupted externally grow three times faster than those that wait. The organisations that break their own paradigms are the

ones that lead. The ones that protect them are the ones that, eventually, get broken by someone else.

Creating Time for Creating the Future

One of the most practical expressions of the choice to create rather than manage is the protection of time for creation.

We have seen this choice made consciously and visibly by leaders in organisations we work with closely.

The Managing Director and the Director of a manufacturing company in Karnataka made a deliberate, structural decision: one full day per week, ring-fenced and non-negotiable, dedicated entirely to creating the future — not managing the routine. Not reviewing dashboards. Not resolving escalations. Building what has not yet been built.

A leadership team of a Mumbai-based company made a similar commitment and have been progressively moving toward three dedicated days per week for building the future. Not someday. Now. As an investment made in advance of the returns it will produce.

These are not large companies with the luxury of detachment. These are working CEOs, with full calendars and real pressures. The difference between them and the organisations still trapped in BUSYness is not capacity. It is intention.

You Cannot Delegate the Momentum of Change

Here is something every leader who has tried to drive organisational transformation discovers, usually the hard way.

The moment you step back, the organisation drifts back. Not dramatically. Not all at once. But steadily, reliably, the gravitational pull of the familiar reclaims the space the leader vacated.

When the leader drives forward, the organisation moves forward. When the leader steps back — even with the best intentions of empowering the team — the organisation drifts. Back toward comfort. Back toward the existing paradigm. Back toward BUSYness.

This is not a criticism of the team. It is a description of how transformation actually works. The team drifts not because they are weak or uncommitted, but because the conditions for them to sustain transformation on their own have not yet been built.

You can share the leadership of transformation. You can build a team that carries it with you. But you cannot delegate its energy — not until the culture has been genuinely transformed, not just described.

From Company to Ecosystem

Most leaders build organisations. Good leaders build outstanding organisations and durable ecosystems — leaving the space around them stronger than they found it.

Jeff Bezos built the orientation of creation into Amazon's cultural DNA from the company's earliest days. He called it Day 1 — a permanent orientation toward invention, toward what does not yet exist, toward the question of what would be created if the organisation were starting fresh today. His warning about its

opposite was equally precise: "Day 2 is stasis. Followed by irrelevance. Followed by excruciating, painful decline." Every Amazon leadership meeting begins with the Day 1 question. Not as ritual. As an active refusal to treat existing success as a reason to stop creating.

What does an ecosystem mindset look like in practice? Instead of thinking of customers as outside the boundary, you think of them as co-creators of value. Instead of thinking of competitors as adversaries to be defeated, you explore where collaboration expands the entire space. Instead of fighting for a fixed share of a fixed market, you build something that makes the market itself larger.

The organisation at the centre of a healthy ecosystem is not vulnerable to disruption. It *is* the disruption. Not through scale — through architecture.

The Choice Is Made Every Day

The leader's choice is not made in a single dramatic moment of courage. It is made in hundreds of small ones. In every meeting, every conversation, every decision about what to accept and what to challenge. Whether you ask the creative question or the operational one. Whether you defend the existing process or question whether the process is still serving the mission.

Every morning, two options present themselves.

Option One: Manage the existing reality. Accept the current paradigm. Wait for the team to lead. Protect what worked before. Step back when it gets hard.

Option Two: Create the new reality. Break the existing paradigm. Drive the momentum — collectively. Build toward what has not yet been built. Stay the course without resignation.

High-Performance is produced by a leader who makes Option Two — not once, not dramatically, but daily. Without resignation. Without the comfort of "good enough."

Exercises — Chapter 7: Leadership Creates

These exercises are designed to surface where you are managing instead of creating — and to make one act of genuine creation real this week.

Exercise 1: The Creation vs. Management Audit

— What new reality are you currently creating that does not yet exist — not optimising what exists, but creating something new? Name it specifically.

— Where in your leadership are you most prone to managing rather than creating? In one specific current context.

— What question would a creating leader ask in your next leadership meeting that a managing leader would never think to ask?

Exercise 2: The Three Comfort Zones

— Which of the three comfort zones is your organisation most significantly defended by: past ways of working, silos and hierarchy, or past success itself?

— What would it cost, specifically, to break it? Name the discomfort. Name the first action.

— The past success your organisation is most at risk of treating as a ceiling rather than a floor — what is it? What would it mean to use it as a floor instead?

Exercise 3: The Ecosystem Vision

— Name the five most strategic ecosystem relationships your organisation could build — with clients, partners, even competitors — that you have not yet invested in. Why not?

— Beyond your organisation, how are you changing your industry? If your purpose were fully realised, what would your industry look like?

— Have you stepped back from the momentum of change recently? What happened in the organisation when you did?

The Mirror Questions

— What new reality have you been capable of creating for some time — but have been managing instead? What has stopped you?

— Which of the three comfort zones are you personally most attached to?

— What would it look like to stop managing the existing reality and start creating a new one — this week, in one specific context?

The Commitment

I commit to one specific act of creation — not management — this week. Something that did not exist before and will exist because I chose to build it:

The choice between managing and creating is made every day. In hundreds of small moments. Not with a plan. With intention. The leader who makes this choice consistently, without resignation, is the leader who builds something that endures.

Chapter 8 makes that intention concrete. Four non-negotiables. Not aspirations. Not goals. Non-negotiables. Standards that, held firmly by the leader — in themselves first — change the architecture of how the organisation functions. They begin with you. They always begin with you.